

Emergency reset protocol for freelancers

— Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

EXECUTE THE 48-HOUR HARD STOP

- ☐ **Execute the 48-Hour Hard Stop:** Set up an out-of-office message that includes your return date, your unavailability for urgent requests, and an alternative contact person, then activate it immediately.
- ☐ **Execute the 48-Hour Hard Stop:** Send direct messages to clients with active projects explaining you need 48 hours offline and asking what needs your attention before you go dark.
- ☐ **Execute the 48-Hour Hard Stop:** Put your phone in another room and turn off all client communication channels for at least the first 12 hours to truly disconnect and reset.
- ☐ **Execute the 48-Hour Hard Stop:** Take an outdoor walk during hours 12-24 to get natural light on your skin, listening only to music you enjoyed before freelancing consumed your life.

DOCUMENT THE DAMAGE

- ☐ **Document the Damage:** Open a blank document titled "Damage Report" and write down what physical sensations your body is currently experiencing, including any pain, tension, or fatigue.
- ☐ **Document the Damage:** Record in your Damage Report the emotional thoughts and concerns you've been actively avoiding thinking about, even if they seem unfinished or unclear.
- ☐ **Document the Damage:** Identify and write down the smallest possible action you could take right now to begin moving forward from this burnout moment.
- ☐ **Document the Damage:** Notice which clients treated your 48-hour absence as a crisis versus those who were understanding, since this reveals important information about the health of those working relationships.

BEGIN RECOVERY WORK

- ☐ **Begin Recovery Work:** Schedule an appointment with a counselor or mental health professional who can help you identify where your burnout is rooted and develop strategies to counteract it.
 - ☐ **Begin Recovery Work:** Write down five activities you genuinely enjoyed doing before freelancing became your primary identity, so you can reconnect with who you were before the burnout.
 - ☐ **Begin Recovery Work:** Document at least one explicit non-negotiable boundary you will enforce with future clients, such as specific working hours or maximum response time limits.
 - ☐ **Begin Recovery Work:** Create a simple daily check-in habit that doesn't require willpower, such as writing one sentence each morning about how you physically feel that day.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.